

CYCLING THROUGH HIGH WATER TO HELL

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As part of the 1985 University of Toronto performance of and international colloquium on the Towneley 'cycle', David Mills later published his remarks in "The Towneley Plays" or "The Towneley Cycle"?¹ Mills' sense of the dramatic integrity of individual pageants within the context of a mnemonic framework guides this present study of the six extant *Noah* texts, which in structural techniques, figuration, and memory can propel an audience from Old Testament salvation story to New Testament Judgement pageants. The *Judgement* pageants are not treated here except by inference, but correspondences and echoes between the two salvation episodes would reward further attention. 'From the outset' Chester Cycle editors Mills and R.M. Lumiansky 'saw the plays as the centre of an ever-widening range of contexts' and Mills later observed that, 'The plays respond to the changes around them by assuming new forms, in performance and in text, being repeatedly reinvented and revived to meet the changing needs of the town'.² The variety and change which he marked in Chester also holds for the other extant 'cycle' texts, and this piece on the *Noah* pageants thus is offered in tribute to David Mills' inspirational eye for both text and performance.

In part, David's article so impressed me because at the time he was one of the few people who agreed with me about the general nature of the Towneley manuscript. As *he* put it, 'The manuscript could almost be an idiosyncratic assemblage of material from a variety of sources into a sort of presentation volume, using a Creation-Doomsday framework of organisation'.³ As *I* put it, Wakefield local historian and physician J.M.W. Walker had invented or appropriated all but three of the putative drama records cited in his *History of Wakefield*, by means of which he, and most of David's and my colleagues, identified the Towneley manuscript with a Wakefield Corpus Christi guild cycle.⁴ Eventually I was able to create a respectable albeit speculative history for that 'idiosyncratic assemblage' of the Towneley pageants, and David

returned to the relative safety of 'Chester's nervously defensive and tonally consistent "Bible-cycle"'.⁵

In 'The Towneley Plays' Mills notes that 'play-cycles have traditionally been considered to have two interlocking frames': the historical, by which he means the authorized written narrative of biblical events and commentaries; and the generic, which he defines as 'the dramatisation of selections from that [historical] narrative initiated by the play of *Creation* and closed by the play of *Doomsday*'.⁶ As Mills appreciates, such 'goal-seeking' frames undervalue an audience's process of 'mental reconstitution', an invitation for 'the audience to recognise the selective, fragmented nature of the play-material they are witnessing and to search into their own memories of that historical frame'.⁷ In short, the unplayed pageants are recalled by the played so that in some respects those missing are retrieved by those present. In the process, the audience is pulled into an interactive role as participants in the very creation of the drama, a point to which I shall return.

This notion 'that cycle-form is a product of mental reconstitution and that one function of a cycle-narrative or play might be to excite such a reconstitution' is immensely attractive for several reasons.⁸ First, it better accommodates what historical shreds and patches of play cycles, both texts and records, survive. Since our early suspicions that the Towneley was a *compilatio*, the 'norm' of medieval drama — pageant-mounted processional Corpus Christi cycles performed by craft guilds — has been deconstructed into more variations than uniformities. As evidence of those variations continues to grow through the REED project's accumulation of single parish plays, cooperative parish plays, alternations of single plays, remnants of apparent cycles, and so forth, we are invited to look at our few surviving texts as potentially independent plays, to look at them as individual performance pieces rather than as more or less competent pieces of an historical whole. Granted that such an approach curtails the past century's cottage industry of speculation about missing leaves, missing bindings, missing stanzas, missing pageants, missing banns (and the occasional suspect supply of lacunae, like Walker's or Collier's), but such an approach produces the enormous advantage of enfranchising the audience's role, an enfranchisement which is at the heart and soul of Elizabethan drama. Earlier 'goal-seeking' frames asked us to postulate whole cycles, however

fractured their remains; and, further, to imagine those cycles passively and reverently observed by unlettered, awestruck peasants.

How much more liberating to the history and development of early English drama it is to imagine an interactive audience supplying from memory what on this particular occasion they are not seeing; borrowing from other pageants perhaps seen last year or reported by folks from nearby towns; visualizing the parish church window or wall painting; recollecting the old man and his young wife over the ginnel, the alewife up the snicket; calling to mind bits of last Sunday's sermon — the rich collage of human memory applied to the present offering. Audience memory thus becomes interactive, a creative agent in shaping the performance; and the pageant text is enriched by a process of figuration or typology, partially, perhaps, from prior or missing performances, certainly from the socio-cultural contexts of life itself. I am suggesting a broader definition of typology or figuration than that suggested by V.A. Kolve and others — but not one more broad than that suggested by Arnold Williams many years ago. In discussing criteria for effective typological exegesis, he reminded his graduate seminars that typology is a metaphor, a transference which deepens the meaning of the expressed object or person by attachment with the unexpressed object or person. He cautioned that the transference cannot be so obvious as to not engage the reader's or viewer's mental energy — too shallow and one feels no victory in having made the transference. Secondly, and Williams was a pioneer in attention to performance, he insisted that typology had to be theatrically possible, a consideration largely ignored by Kolve and other Corpus Christi cycle conceptualists.

Figuration must be communicated on stage to an audience through theatrical means for it to be effective. A medieval play, to its audience, had no text: it had to be grasped on first watching by an audience which one has no reason to believe was a learned coterie of playgoers. Rather, however, the medieval playwright could predict a large group of churchgoers familiar with the liturgy and with the iconography of their churches, leading to the conclusion that effective dramatic typology must be obvious, as opposed to studied or abstruse, and it must be popular, drawing not only from liturgical typology but from the familiar types and images of daily life. The reward of such typology in early modern drama is significant as it enhances and deepens the pageant's significance for the audience. Among the many means by which

medieval cycle texts engage their audiences is their manipulation of stock characters, frequently condemned by modern critics as 'stereotypical' or 'derivative' but in fact a masterful melding of biblical typology with human type. As Williams notes, 'Dramatists of all ages, Shakespeare among them, have found stock characters and situations useful. Audiences expect and accept them. They save time, and there is always the delight in recognition ... Stock characters and situations are ubiquitous simply because they correspond to ubiquitous experience'.⁹

One of the most valuable bequests of Mills' (and, before him, Williams') legacies has been the conversion of a generation from dismissing these plays as 'trifling little speeches' and 'crude dramatic construction' into a generation who, at least conditionally, (1) trusts the text and (2) tries to think creatively about turning texts into scripts. Verse drama, provincial dialects, and closed stanzas make the cycle texts notoriously difficult to deliver. 'A cursory reading of the cycles is likely to lead only to an endorsement of Marlowe's famous characterization of his immediate predecessors: 'the jiggling veins of riming mother wits'.¹⁰ When coached, however, modern actors have proved to deliver the lines well, with meaning, with clarity, without sing-song or, worse, without condescending sing-song mockery, to notice textual punctuation but to override it if a unit of meaning needs to subordinate rhyme or metre.¹¹

Secondly, as these pageants have come down to us, they are 'regynalls', official records of approved texts, and not playing scripts. Thus intelligent, and intelligible, modern players need to read the silences; take the pauses; act and react to each other; and supply the stagecraft of blocking, sound, light, gesture, and spectacle which make text and characterization sensible rather than stupid. Writing of the Towneley Uxor's sudden, apparently unmotivated action of boarding the Ark, Williams cautions that, 'Critics who have called this crude dramatic construction have missed the point. If we suppose some terrifying natural interruption to the quarrel, a monstrous peal of thunder or the roar of a high wind, the scene is not only playable, it becomes a theatrical triumph'.¹² Likewise the York Uxor's Ark-boarding line of 'We! Owte! Herrowe!' and the Newcastle Noah's physical reaction to the Devil's drink — 'What the devil, what drink is it!' — are silly if read, dynamic if staged.

Particularly dynamic both as individual performance pieces and also as figurative prompters within the larger context of 'the cycle' are the six

surviving *Noah* texts. Although in many respects they resemble each other — e.g. their place within an historical or generic cycle and their similar spiritual themes — in many other respects they are highly individualistic, particularly in dramatic techniques. As Williams notes, ‘Of course, the first-time reader is apt to find most cycle plays on the same subject remarkably similar, just as one Gothic cathedral looks like another when the tourist is seeing his first half dozen ... Greater familiarity with the form and closer inspection of individual samples, whether of plays or cathedrals, produces astonishment at the inexhaustible variety’.¹³ The analysis which follows focuses on three dramatic elements — structure, performance requirements, and mnemonic cues triggered by figuration or typology. Meant to be suggestive rather than explicative, this study invites the reader to return to the texts rather than flooding him and her with quotations. The invitation asks the reader by directions to find indirections out — to prod the text for performance possibilities as an actor or director rather than as a dramaturge or exegete. Secondly, the invitation asks the reader to shelve mentally the five-act structure and length as retrogressive prototypes for these pageants, to not judge their structural elements harshly because they are not continuous or even contiguous to a later norm.

Probably earliest of the surviving versions, the York manuscript (and Roger Burton’s 1415 *Ordo Paginarum*) divides the Noah episode into the Shipwrights’ dramatically taut Ark-building pageant, which in turn serves as introduction to a finely-crafted Fishers’ and Mariners’ ensemble pageant of the Flood. The Ark-building pageant is a duologue, opened by Deus with a three-stanza direct address to the audience before he introduces Noah.¹⁴ As their duologue develops, so do exposition, characterization, plot, conflict, and figuration. Deus’ initial audience address frames the biblical context, Noah’s concluding stanza to Deus and audience makes the transition to the next unit, Pageant 9. In between, Deus has 67 lines to Noah, Noah 69 to Deus, and of those lines they split four stanzas with Deus assigned the closing quatrains in all four.¹⁵ The alternating speeches and equal division of lines with their opportunities for comic possibilities almost force the two players into a dynamic ‘act and react’ relationship: of particular comic promise are Noah’s ignorance of ship-building, Deus’ Ark specifications, and Noah’s age as he claims here to be vocationally unwieldy in a figuration of Joseph’s sexual unwieldiness.¹⁶ Moreover, the

dramatic equitability permits sufficient conflict between God and Noah to figure those conflicts which on a grand scale will lead to Doomsday.

The performance requirements of this remarkable little pageant are minimal — two players and part of a pre-built Ark, or at least a board with a pre-bored bolt hole, 'cement', nails, and a curved board as bow and as figure of the following York pageant's rainbow. Alone among the six extant *Noah* texts, the York Shipwrights' pageant asks mainly for ship parts rather than the troublesome property itself, throwing focus on the duologue between Deus and Noah (including Deus' last-minute instruction for Noah to add tiered chambers to what he has) rather than on spectacle. Noah's Ark clearly presents a performance challenge, which the various texts solve in their various ways. In the York *Flood* pageant, the Ark is present, completed, and easy of access as action moves from Ark to 'home' to Ark, from low in the Ark to high in the Ark. In Chester, the Ark is pre-fabricated: Noah has two stanzas to assemble the pieces ('These bordes I pynne here together ... Of this tree will I make a maste'), and his family, apparently armed with expansive toolkits, then tackles the finishing work.¹⁷ Playing on dramatic convention, especially a collaborative, interactive audience willing to suspend its disbelief, the Chester Ark-building is largely mimed. The N.Town pageant admits of no performance ambiguity: *Hic transit Noe cum familia sua pro nauī, quo exeunte locum interludii sub intret statim Lameth conductus ab adolescente ... Hic recedat Lameth et statim intrat Noe cum nauī cantantes* ('Here Noah crosses [the playing-place] with his family to get the ship and on his exit from the playing place let Lamech come in at once, led by a youth' and 'Here let Lameth exit and at once Noah with the ship enters the playing-place, [all] singing'), the Lameth interlude spanning Noah's off-platea Ark-building.¹⁸ The faulty Newcastle text, which even in its marred remission suggests theatrical proficiency, divides Ark-building between the aged Noah's exhausting attempt to go it alone and the angel's apparently effective intervention. Along similar lines but admitting any number of imaginative staging solutions is the Towneley text, which asks for cooperation between developing Noah's aged, exhausted character while also developing the Ark.¹⁹

Of the many, three dimensions of York Pageant 9, the Fishers and Mariners *Flood*, deserve particular attention for the expertise with which they are handled. Unless Deus or Angels are silent actors, this pageant requires eight

players, the fundamental ensemble unit at its dramatic core — four couples, three of whom are passive and peaceable, one of whom is dynamic and volatile. Interplay among the eight can be as inventive as the players wish: definition of their respective characters and relationships is a given for ensemble players, about which more below. In the ensemble process, the ‘realistic’ time frame of this pageant is developed as the action is more between and during the lines than in them. Fleshing out the text with action, gesture, music, the ‘business’ of feeding animals or asking Noah questions, the Sons and Daughters fill the time span, add realism with their questions, and further develop Noah’s character by his answers. Action moves easily from Ark to home to Ark, from low in Ark to high in Ark to dry ground, and the dialogue in this pageant is especially ‘natural’.

From Noah’s introduction of himself as the son of Lamech, who lived 777 years and prophesied that Noah would be a comfort to mankind, the pageant adroitly weaves between past and future typology of the saved and the one who saves. Properties are minimal in this pageant of words: in addition to the Ark, perhaps elevated on a waggon or platform, given the text’s numerous references to height, it needs only a lead weight on a cord, a raven, a dove, an olive branch, and probably a rainbow. Noah and Uxor are stock characters, but the text shows a deft hand in tailoring their stereotypically contentious relationship to the immediate crisis. Central to Noah’s character is a male pragmatism of doing what needs to be done, ‘fixing it’, ‘getting on with it’; central to Uxor’s is a domestic love of the familiar, rejection of the unknown, and aversion to risk. These broadly conventional gender traits, however, are embroidered with marital subtleties — he has told *everyone* but her, she *always* is the last to know, he *never* tells her anything, she *never* knows where he is, he is *never* at home, and she is going *nowhere*, end of the world or not, without going home to truss her tools — pack her ‘stuff’. These charges are as familiar today as they would have been when directed to the fifteenth-century York audiences. A woman who has not had time to pack her curling iron or favorite skillet is a dangerous creature, even in the face of the Flood.

David Mills has covered the staging possibilities and modern representations of the *Chester Flood* so intelligently that here I only want to look at two of the play’s dramatic strengths.²⁰ As Mills notes, ‘The play has as background the town and its society, and Noah should be imagined as a

craftsman whose sons are following him into the trade, while his wife is a prosperous burgess's wife with a circle of drinking-companions whom she does not want to abandon to sail in an absurdly designed vessel'.²¹ What the Chester playwright has done is to use 'the town and its society' — the audience — in a collaborative and imaginative creative process. Of the six pageants, the Chester asks the most help from its audience to bring it into artistic being. With a minimum of eleven players — and more if there are more than two Gossips plus silent agents to drown them — this pageant also requires an expansive number of properties. Besides the pre-fabricated Ark with its animal panels and 'the clowdes, if it may bee',²² the text calls for an axe, hatchet, hammer, timber, chopping block, probably buckets for slitch, chips to make fire, tree for the mast, cables or ropes, cross-bars or spars for the sails, a topcastle (platform on the top of the mast), and a bowsprit (the spar jutting forward from the prow).

These numerous hand properties point to careful dramatic crafting of the Chester ensemble: in 'building' their Ark, they have an opportunity to develop and differentiate their characters, invent appropriate business, and engage the audience with comic interaction. One is reminded of the old adage that there are no bit parts in a good play, and the Chester *Noah* is a very, very good play. Apparently indistinguishable from each other except by their names and tools, the three Sons share in a medieval 'convention of three' — three shepherds, three torturers, three soldiers, three mothers (although, oddly, not in the Chester *Herod* where there are two), three demons, three good souls, three bad souls. Sometimes the trio are undifferentiated from each other to amplify their common characteristic — e.g. cruelty — but as often the three represent variations on a common identity — e.g. the Towneley Shepherds. The Chester Sons and Daughters-in-Law, as in York and Towneley, contribute to the pageant's humour if their characters and the relations between them vary. One notices, for example, that the sons carry hand tools, while the women do the heavy lifting of boards, chopping block, and slitch buckets, as Uxor sardonically volunteers:

And wee shall bringe tymber to,
for wee mon nothings ells doe —

women bynne weake to underfoe
any great travell.²³

The Chester audience is essential to this pageant's dynamic, and the writer trusts his audience to help create the experience. Without audience collaboration, much of the action is childlike; with audience 'suspension of disbelief' comes shared delight in pantomime and pretend. Both Noah and Uxor extend their quarrel to a gendered audience; 'Noe with all his familye shall make a signe as though the wrought upon the shippe with diverse instruements'; the audience clearly shares in the identification game with animals painted on boards, particularly if Uxor acts out her rather predacious group of bears, wolves, apes, owls, marmosets, weasels, squirrels, and ferrets; and the pageant's disregard of time — seven days to bring in the animals and set sail, forty days of rain, 120 years to build the ark — asks the audience to substitute stage time for real.

Two other *Noah* pageants, N.Town and Newcastle, also ask for collaborative help from the audience but in quite a different manner from Chester. Rather than piecing out the Chester 'imperfections', like painted rabbits and redshanks, with our thoughts, both the N.Town and Newcastle texts ask us to provide connective tissue, largely through figuration and typology. What scholars of Elizabethan drama would praise as 'multiple plotting' had been competently developed many years earlier. Of the N.Town pageants, Williams notes, 'The chief literary feature of *Ludus*—and an unexpected one in so learned a piece — is its theatrical maturity. No other cycle devotes such attention to working out exciting bits of stage business, no other is so deft in what the cinema calls "short cutting", the rapid alternation of scenes to advance a plot along several lines almost simultaneously'.²⁴ The creator of the N.Town *Noah* text is superbly confident in juxtaposing disparate episodes with the expectation that his audience will infer their common meaning. The sins of the father are visited upon the head of the son, as Noah's entering lament suggests, but here the foreshadowed son looks forward to the redeemer in figure of Christ while the father Lameth looks backward as he commits both a metaphoric and a literal hamartia in shooting the son of Adam and Eve. Figuration is quite dense in this pageant: in his initial address to the audience, Noah directly points to himself as progenitor of the Second

Age, Second Father after Adam. Chem's wife prays that she 'nevyr in daunger crepe / On dredfull Domysday',²⁵ foreshadowing the Judgment. The Lameth interlude figures his bow for shooting Cain, beating the boy to death, and foreshadowing the rainbow, while still grounded in the dramatic prototype, here not comic, of the saucy young servant's misguiding the blind old man.²⁶

Even in its marred and perplexing state, the Newcastle-upon-Tyne Shipwrights' Play shows the same confident juxtaposition of disparate episodes while leaving the audience to infer their commonality. Noah exits to build his Ark with a direct warning to the audience that 'Therefore, [*men*,] or ever you blin, / You *mend* your *life* and turn your thought ...' (91-2);²⁷ the Devil enters immediately and also addresses the audience, revealing his motivation and plan as boldly as Shakespeare's Richard III some years later. The angel's difficulty in waking the sleeping and then groggy Noah foreshadows his drunken nakedness and shame in Genesis 9:20-29, while the Devil's temptation of Uxor harkens back to the Serpent's temptation of Eve. Although the extant text often is characterized as only half a play, breaking off after the Ark is built, its present ending seems quite deliberate, a rounded conclusion which in fact presents this shipbuilding episode as a psychomachia-to-come, a battle not only for Noah's microcosmic soul but also for the macrocosmic salvation of mankind. Effective blocking at this pageant's suspended 'to be continued' end would place Noah between the Angel on his right and Devil on his left as the Angel's final stanza blesses Noah, Noah's final stanza blesses the audience, and the Devil's final stanza curses '[a]ll that is gathered in this stead'.

'All that is gathered in this *stead*' (emphasis mine) suggests that here is perhaps the place to make a few observations about place in these pageants. Although many 'cycle' studies have focused on performance places — pageant waggon, platea, scaffold, side-on, end-on, three-storied, flatbed — they have neglected the surviving texts' most frequent playing site, namely the unlocalized space given 'a local habitation and a name' by the players. Clearly in the *Noah* pageants the ship, whether visible, invisible, or in-progress, is one dominant playing place, but the other is characterized by whatever the texts say that it is: 'heere', 'harde lande', 'without the arke', 'this place here', 'this towne', 'here on rowe', '*locum*', '*statim*', 'henceforth', 'this medill-erd', 'homward', 'thederward', 'on this hill', 'on this sole', 'hither'. In the York *Flood* pageant, Uxor is 'here', 'on harde lande', the rest of the family 'on toure

deraye', which Beadle glosses as 'in utter confusion' but which also is Uxor's pejorative for the elevated ship itself as she tells Noah that 'In faythe þou were als goode come downe' (83).²⁸ The initial stage direction of the Chester *Noah* puts God 'in some high place — or in the clowdes, if it may bee'; the Towneley *Noah* prays to Deus in his 'hall/ In heuen' but Deus in fact does not speak nor does Noah see him until he hastily has gone to his servant, Noah, 'thus low to appere' on earth. In short, not only are places but often events — floods waxing and waning, the return of dry ground — visualized by words rather than by properties or physical settings.

Finally we come to the Towneley *Processus Noe cum filiis Wakefeld*, a pageant which quite easily could stand alone — and perhaps did — outside a cycle. A summary of the Old Testament events which led to the Flood and a precursor of the New Testament sequence, it also is a collective of early English dramatic techniques crafted by a master playwright. His most startling gift, I would argue, is his ability to take apparently conventional devices — the set speech, the stock character, the extended monologue, the tedious exposition — and slyly turn them, and us, on our ears. The comic possibilities of the Towneley *Noah* text are almost unlimited, although one must not be blind to Williams' caution that 'perhaps one should be sceptical about the contemporary effect of a scene written hundreds of years ago and played to an audience with decidedly different notions of what was comic'.²⁹ Williams' concern, however, is about misunderstanding pieces which 'were not intended as comic when they were written' and my far greater concern with the Towneley *Noah* is that we may well have solemnized now what was comic then. Surely the Towneley Deus is anthropomorphic: his monologue divides easily into beats which express shifting emotions, and his notion of ship building is less than omniscient as he piles detail upon detail in a most peculiar order. That Noah does not recognize Deus and must ask his name suggests that Deus wears a human disguise, perhaps cloaked as a pilgrim in a bit of New Testament figurative foreshadowing.

Noah's opening monologue, part prayer, part exposition, part direct audience address, part character revelation, is equally complex and eminently worthy of dynamic performance rather than static recitation. On the surface Noah and Uxor are stock characters — the shrewish wife, the henpecked husband — but their layered, subtle, and entertaining relationship simmers

throughout the play, threatening to boil over at any point. The playwright gives them repeated opportunities to clash: two slapstick physical battles with a whip and staff for weapons, numerous pointed exchanges, thrust-and-parry baiting and bickering, ironic reversals of injury claims with physical superiority, two *chansons de mal mariée* from Uxor to audience wives, two *chansons de mal marié* from Noah to audience husbands, and even a difference of opinion on the birds.³⁰ With all of this conflict, however, the playwright also gives them brief breathing spaces to rest and reconcile so that their final harmony is a marital resolution rather than a surprise. In the Towneley's Noah and Uxor, one can see something of the prototypes which will lead to Theseus and Hippolyta, Katharina and Petruchio, Beatrice and Benedick.

Elizabethan and Jacobean drama owes much to the cycle plays, as is evident from just the six *Noah* pageants, let alone the full panoply of biblical episode and dramatic technique. Picking out meaningful actions; unapologetic peripeteia, sudden turns of events or unexpected reversals; variations in mood and tempo; flexibility or disregard of time; songs and magic in plays; mixed modes of comedy from slapstick to situation to manners; and suspense — marvellous gifts of medieval inheritance. Further, these medieval plays use comedy to reflect and reinforce serious themes, the progenitor of multiple plotting which ultimately gives universal extension to an otherwise isolated incident and which suggests to later playwrights the idea of making microcosmic acts reverberate through the macrocosm as in *Julius Caesar*, *King Lear*, *Macbeth*. The duologues for exposition and foreshadowed conflict between Noah and Deus extend to *King Lear* ('I thought the King had more affected the Duke of Albany than Cornwall') and *The Winter's Tale* ('If you shall chance, Camillo, to visit Bohemia ... you shall see ... great difference betwixt our Bohemia and your Sicilia'). Ensemble units, groupings of three, dynamic monologues divided into beats which reveal character and thought as they unravel — more marvelous gifts of medieval inheritance. The greatest gift of all, however, from the earliest biblical pageant to the 1642 closing of the theatres, is audience collaboration. These texts reach out to their audiences in any number of ways, and they trust their audiences' imagination, intelligence, perceptiveness, wit, familiarity with types, and, as David Mills noted, memory. These 'simple religious plays' have left a rich dramatic heritage, a heritage

which would be far less appreciated were it not for David Mills' equally rich scholarship over the years.

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NOTES

1. David Mills "The Towneley Plays" or "The Towneley Cycle" *Leeds Studies in English* 17 (1986) 95–104.
2. David Mills *Recycling the Cycle: The City of Chester and Its Whitsun Plays* (Studies in Early English Drama 4; Toronto: University of Toronto Press, 1998) viii, 18.
3. Mills 'Towneley Plays' 95.
4. Barbara D. Palmer "Towneley Plays" or "Wakefield Cycle" Revisited' *Comparative Drama* 21 (1987–1988) 318–48; reprinted in *Drama in the Middle Age: Comparative and Critical Essays 2nd Series* edited by Clifford Davidson and John H. Stroupe (AMS Studies in the Middle Ages 18; New York: AMS Press, 1991) 290–320.
5. Barbara D. Palmer 'Recycling "The Wakefield Cycle": The Records' *Research Opportunities in Renaissance Drama* 41 (2002) 88–130; Mills 'Towneley Plays' 102.
6. Mills 'Towneley Plays' 96
7. Mills 'Towneley Plays' 96, 97.
8. Mills 'Towneley Plays' 96
9. Arnold Williams *The Drama of Medieval England* (East Lansing: Michigan State University Press, 1961) 121.
10. Williams *Drama* 135.
11. Although the performance was a delight, full of spectacle, business, and holiday humour, the Folger Shakespeare Library and Folger Consort's December 2007 production of the Towneley *Secunda Pastorum* unfortunately was an example of not trusting the text — or of not making the language either intelligent or intelligible.
12. Williams *Drama* 115.
13. Williams *Drama* 64–5.
14. To assume that Deus is either talking to himself or delivering his lines in a static monotone is to ignore their wonderfully performable alliteration and such implied gestures to the audience as 'made I man', 'Lorde and syre on ilke a side', 'medillerthe', and 'A woman'.

15. As in blank-verse lines split between two characters, the final position is the more authoritative.
16. The Ark would be approximately 153 metres long, 26 metres broad, and fifteen metres high, dimensions which probably would attract Noah's attention. American readers will remember comedian Bill Cosby's 1963 album (*Bill Cosby is a Very Funny Fellow: Right!*) with his routines on 'Noah: Right!', 'Noah: And the Neighbor', and Noah: Me and You, Lord'. After the Lord delivers his lengthy Ark instructions, an exceedingly long silence finally is punctured by Cosby's benumbed 'What's a cubit?'
17. *The Chester Mystery Cycle* edited R.M. Lumiansky and David Mills, 2 vols, *EETS SS* 3 and 9 (1974, 1986) 1 45.
18. *The N-Town Play, Cotton MS Vespasian D.8* edited by Stephen Spector, 2 vols *EETS SS* 11 and 12 (1991) 1 45, 47.
19. In May 1985, the University of Toronto's Graduate Centre for the Study of Drama gave David Klausner's Towneley *Noah* two angels; a few years earlier, Chatham College, Pittsburgh, used unseen humans at the back of the Ark to effect miraculous sleight-of-hand progress at the front of the Ark.
20. *The Chester Mystery Cycle: A New Edition with Modernized Spelling* edited by David Mills (*Medieval Texts and Studies* 9; East Lansing, Michigan: Colleagues Press, 1992) 50.
21. Mills *Chester Mystery Cycle: New Edition* 49.
22. A Ripon Minster, West Riding, Yorkshire fabric roll records expenses for making clouds for the Holy Ghost which go up and down during Ascension and Pentecost: Leeds: University of Leeds Brotherton Library, MS Ripon F.R.19 mb 1d. To be published in the *REED: West Riding* collection edited by Barbara D. Palmer and John M. Wasson.
23. Lumiansky and Mills *Chester Cycle* 1 44.
24. Williams *Drama* 62, 67. Oddly, however, he sees the Lameth episode as 'an out-of-place scene of the blind archer, Lamech, shooting Cain by mistake for a beast' rather than as a deliberate typological interlude.
25. Spector *N-Town* 43.
26. For example, Lancelot Gobbo and Old Gobbo in *Merchant of Venice* or Gloucester and Edgar in *King Lear*.
27. 'Noah's Ark; or, The Shipwrights' Ancient Play or Dirge' in *Non-Cycle Plays and Fragments* edited Norman Davis *EETS SS* 1 (1970) 19-31, at 28. See also John Anderson and A.C. Cawley 'The Newcastle Play of Noah's Ark' *REED Newsletter*

1977:1 11–17. The earliest printed text of the Newcastle-upon-Tyne ‘Shipwrights’ Play or Noah’s Ship’ was by Henry Bourne in 1736; his version and others following are problematic and the manuscript from which Bourne presumably worked no longer is extant.

28. *The York Plays* edited Richard Beadle (London: Edward Arnold, 1982) 80, 84–5, Glossary 527.
29. Williams *Drama* 24.
30. Barbara D. Palmer “‘To speke of wo that is in mariage’: The Marital Arts in Medieval Literature’ in *Human Sexuality in the Middle Ages and Renaissance* edited Douglas Radcliff-Umstead (Pittsburgh: University of Pittsburgh Press, 1978) 3–14 at 12.